

THE LONG TAKE

Written by Ouroboros (synthetic placeholder script for Phase 3 testing)

FADE IN:

INT. MAYA'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - MORNING

MAYA CHEN (28), a documentary editor with tired eyes, pours coffee into a Starbucks travel mug. A can of Coca-Cola sits unopened on the counter next to a MacBook Pro, its Apple logo glowing faintly.

The kitchen radio plays. A DJ's voice fades into the opening piano chords of "Bohemian Rhapsody" by Queen.

RADIO DJ (V.O.)
That was the news at eight. And now,
a classic from Queen.

Maya hums along, badly, as she scrolls her phone. A news alert flashes: a photo of Barack Obama at a climate summit.

MAYA
(to herself)
Every year it's the same speech.

INT. MAYA'S APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

A framed print of Vincent van Gogh's "The Starry Night" hangs crookedly above the couch. Beside it, a smaller print of the Mona Lisa, slightly dusty.

Maya's roommate, PRIYA SHARMA (27), enters wearing a faded Nike t-shirt, scrolling through messages.

PRIYA
Tata Motors called back. They want
the interview shot by Friday.

MAYA

Tell them I need one more day. I'm still cutting the Golden Gate Bridge sequence.

PRIYA

You and that bridge. It's not even the interesting part of the film.

MAYA

It's the only shot that isn't a lie.

EXT. GOLDEN GATE BRIDGE - DAY (ARCHIVAL FOOTAGE)

Grainy 16mm footage, clearly decades old. Fog rolls under the towers. A voiceover, aged and warm, plays over the shot.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

They said it couldn't be built. They were wrong, the way people are wrong about most bridges.

INT. RECORDING STUDIO - NIGHT

A cramped studio. PRIYA sits at a mixing desk. On the wall behind her, a poster for a concert -- unmistakably Tesla's logo stamped in the corner as a sponsor.

She cues up a track. The unmistakable opening bars of "Happy Birthday to You" hum through the monitors, off-key, recorded live at a party.

PRIYA

This is the clip Maya wants for the birthday montage. Copyright's going to be a nightmare.

SOUND ENGINEER

Isn't it public domain now?

PRIYA

Depends who you ask. And where.

INT. MAYA'S APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - LATER

Maya paces, reciting lines under her breath, rehearsing narration for the documentary's close.

MAYA

"To be, or not to be" -- that's Hamlet,
not me, but it's how I feel about
this cut.

She stops in front of a small television. On screen, a clip of
Serena Williams serving at match point, freeze-framed
mid-swing.

MAYA (CONT'D)

Cut that in after the bridge. People
need to see someone who actually wins.

EXT. TIMES SQUARE - DAY (STOCK FOOTAGE)

Chaotic, neon-lit crowds. A massive screen overhead plays a
car
commercial -- a red convertible, the word FORD barely visible
on
the grille.

NARRATOR (V.O.)

Everyone here is selling something.
Even the silence.

INT. CAFE LUMIERE - AFTERNOON

A cozy, entirely fictional cafe -- Maya's invention, not a
real
place. She sits across from an OLD PROFESSOR, ALBERT WEISS
(70s),
who taught her at film school. A single black-and-white photo
of
Albert Einstein is tacked to the corkboard behind them,
alongside

student notes.

ALBERT

You're still chasing the bridge shot.

MAYA

It's the only honest frame in the whole film.

ALBERT

Honesty is expensive. Ask Coca-Cola's lawyers.

Maya laughs despite herself.

INT. MAYA'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Maya alone, laptop open, the Apple logo the only light in the room. She types a note to herself.

MAYA (V.O.)

Scene forty-one. Replace the Coke can.
Replace the Nike shirt. Keep the
bridge. Keep Einstein. Keep Hamlet.
Cut Obama -- too current, changes too
fast. Keep everything that can't
change.

FADE OUT.

THE END.